

4.7 million tourists to fill the hotels?

The MHRA's figure for planned hotel beds, tested against its own study and Eurostat

THE CLAIM

“Malta will need to attract 4.7 million tourists ... [to] reach 80 percent occupancy throughout the year.”

Tony Zahra, President of the MHRA, Horeca Malta, 23 December 2022

Omitted words: “each spending an average of 7 nights in Malta”. On the MHRA's Deloitte study; repeated in Nov 2024.

We read the study and its slides in full and recomputed every table.

VERDICT

LARGELY SUPPORTED

The figure is in the study; its 80% condition is not.

SUPPORTED

LARGELY
SUPPORTED

NOT
SUBSTANTIATED

MISLEADING

CONTRADICTED

MAIN RESULTS

4.68m

In the study: one scenario

Airport table, p. 66: guest nights +70% on 2019, 7-night stays. Its other cases: 4.41m and 4.96m.

4.1–4.5m

Its bed-stock table and slides

Tourists needed to keep 2019 occupancy if the expected beds are built. 2024 update: 4.4–4.8m.

75.4%

Hotel room occupancy, 2019

Eurostat; bed-places 66.2%. The study kept 2019 rates, not 80%. Only 4-star hotels reached 81.2%.

4.6–5.0m

The same beds at 80%

Our calculation from the study's own bed scenarios: the figure survives the 80% condition.

+20.9%

Hotel bed-places since 2019

Eurostat, 2019 to 2025. The study assumed collective beds +80% to +100%; MTA lists 27,672 approved.

FAIR TO SAY

The MHRA's warning rests on its own study, and the arithmetic holds. What is overstated is the condition: the study used 2019 occupancy, and 4.7 million is one of several scenarios.

WHAT WOULD SETTLE IT

☐ MHRA: the source of the 80% figure.

☐ MHRA: do 'the beds we have' include the pipeline?

☐ PA: approved but unbuilt hotel beds.

☐ MTA: the pipeline by year of opening.